

PANKAJ NANGIA



Singing a New Note

SRINAGAR With an eye on the forthcoming assembly elections due this year, the People's Democratic Party (PDP) and its father-daughter leadership duo are throwing hyperbolic proposals in public space that have not even been a part of the Kashmir-specific dialogue between India and Pakistan. At an election campaign rally in the Jammu region, PDP patron and former chief

minister Mufti Mohammad Sayeed said, "There is no harm if currencies of both India and Pakistan are allowed to be used in Kashmir."

This is not the first time that Sayeed has mooted a controversial proposal. In January, senior PDP leader and Finance Minister Tariq Hamid Qarra had proposed a separate currency for J&K, inviting sharp

CURRENCY CALL: Sayeed criticism from its ruling partner in the state Congress. The minister had called the separate currency as part of his party's vision of self-rule.

Analysts see Sayeed's statement as a significant development capable of creating a political storm in the state. National Conference President Omar Abdullah ridiculed Sayeed for having copied the SAARC charter and selling it to the people of Kashmir for votes. The BJP state unit has said that Sayeed and his daughter Mehbooba Mufti were "anti-national" elements and "should be booked". "The PDP has nothing of its own. They are trying to get things from here and there to sell to the people," Abdullah said.

Sayeed and Mehbooba are making consistent efforts to being seen at the forefront of ideating Indo-Pak dialogue on the Kashmir issue. Citing the European example, Sayeed wants Kashmir to become a model for SAARC countries. **by Aijaz Hussain**

In Reverse Gear

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) has perpetually been incurring losses but that hasn't stopped it from notching up another dubious record for itself. The amount of pension payments to the KSRTC's retired employees has overtaken its total salary bill. This year, KSRTC is to pay Rs 20 crore as pension to its 27,000 retired staff as against its annual salary bill of Rs 19 crore

IN THE RED: The KSRTC



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to its 19,000 employees.

The pension scheme was launched in 1984 by the state government without any offer to share the resultant burden. The number of KSRTC's pensioners is expected to touch 32,000 by 2010.

Today, the corporation is deep in the red with its monthly losses crossing Rs 22 crore and arrears—including pension benefits to be paid to employees—touching Rs 212 crore. The KSRTC's monthly revenue is Rs 76 crore as against its expenditure of Rs 98 crore. "Unless the state Government shares the burden of the pension expenditure, KSRTC will collapse," says a senior official. Truly a case of driving in reverse gear.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

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